place, (viz.) visiting Shramanas and Brahmanas and making gifts (to them), visiting the aged and supporting (them) with gold, visiting the people of the country, instructing (them) in morality, and questioning (them) about morality, as suitable for this (occasion).'[4] It was this, Ashoka declared, which gave him supreme pleasure while those in the 'other part', meaning the earlier pleasures, were deemed inferior.

Can these yatras be described as tours? Vihara yatra and dhamma yatra have been generally understood as pleasure tours and dharma tours, respectively, travelling and journeying being their central features. The factor of enjoyment and hedonism in vihara yatras is also evident in descriptions other than Ashoka's. The scholar Manindra Mohan Bose points to the *Mahabharata*, in which a yatra, called the 'Ghosha yatra', of one of the epic villains, Duryodhana, is vividly described. The passage where permission is sought by this character of his father for the yatra reads: 'O monarch, this also is an excellent season for thy son to go ahunting'; and further: 'indeed, we desire very much to go on a hunting expedition and will avail of that opportunity for supervising the tale of our cattle.'[5] However, 'yatra' in ancient India also indicated festivals. Bose's view is that a dharma yatra should be understood as a festival, not a tour. This is academic quibbling over a term with no likelihood of a resolution: perhaps some of the tours were conducted with an air of festivity. The point in our context is that, whether festival or tour, it would have seen the king moving around his realm. This is what the edict suggests when it says he met people in the country ('janapada'). Ashoka was making himself accessible by being often on the move, meeting people of all kinds, donating money and gold, instructing them about the dhamma.

Within a couple of years after he began touring, around 257/256 BCE, the king vested enhanced spiritual responsibility in his officers. Specifically, the rajukkas and pradeshikas and other such local administrative officials were ordered, even while carrying out their routine duties, to undertake an